

CASE STUDY

Off the Grid: The Women of “Area C”

A prototyping project by Impact Data Lab



Photo: courtesy of Hamde Abu Rahma

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About Impact Data Lab

Impact Data Lab (IDL) aims to bring civil society groups into contact with open data and introduce methodologies for data reuse and dissemination. The 2018 IDL program included data exploration, training sessions, and a hands-on prototyping workshop. Three themes—gender, education, and digital rights in Palestine—guided IDL’s content focus.

Impact Data Lab was organized by Visualizing Impact in partnership with Columbia University’s Studio-X Amman. Both VI and Studio-X Amman have worked extensively on data-driven projects in the MENA region.

Visualizing Impact is a non-profit organization that uses data journalism, technology, and design to address critical social issues.

Columbia University’s Studio-X Amman is a regional platform for experimental design and research run by Columbia GSAPP and the Columbia Global Centers



Above: Impact Data Lab participants at MMAG in Amman, Jordan, March 14, 2018

Gender Thematic



“Supporting the Master Planning process for communities in Area C is a way to ensure the economic, social, and political viability of a future Palestinian state and give Palestinian communities the hope for improving the quality of their lives through self-determination.”¹

Background

The choice to include gender as a theme emerged from discussions with staff at A2K4D. It was clear early in our organizing process that gender was a topic of interest within the node, and that programming in the form of assessments, consultations, and webinars would be offered on various dimensions of gender. I saw an opportunity to conduct gender-centric research and explore open data available on the topic of Palestinian women. The intention was to look at data that pertained to women across the occupied Palestinian Territories (oPT), and from that extract the most remarkable data stories. Some of the questions we had as we embarked on this project were: what open data exists on Palestinian women in general and gender gaps in particular? Who are the authors of the research and how does their socio-political location affect the framing of the data? Who is this data useful to and how can we make this data more useful to better understand the challenges of our research target?

In early conversations with gender experts such as Dr. Faihaa Abdel Hadi, Dr. Manal Hamzeh and Nisreen Alami, there was a general consensus that while there is a significant data on the condition of women in the occupied Palestinian territories, the focus is predominantly based on gender status markers such as women’s health and gender based violence (GBV). These indicators, while important, leave out many of the gendered concerns expressed by different groups of women in the West Bank. In [a financing study](#) prepared by Nisreen Alami for UN Women and OCHAoPT, she remarks that funded, gender-targeted humanitarian projects were primarily focused on maternal and neonatal health, followed by tackling gender based violence. Gender based vulnerabilities in protection concerns other than GBV, food security and livelihoods and shelter received a small portion of contributions².

As a wider context for this project, are a multitude of studies that look at how the Israeli occupation impacts males; incarceration figures, unemployment, death, injury etc. however the figures for women are not as available. Albeit not often quantified, the effects of the occupation and the impact of these experiences are in fact just as far-reaching for women.

The Data

¹ [Rebuilding Alliance / Planning in Area C](#)

² Financing Study: Gender Marker Analysis of OPT 2011-2016, p. 5

The “Area C” Gender / Household Survey³ was conducted in June 2014 by Birzeit University Center for Development Studies. The sample size of 1600 households, ultimately representing 8,813 individuals living in the sampled households, The respondents were solely women, who were asked about their households as well as their own experiences and circumstances. One of the reasons the pod chose to focus on this particular survey was because it contains high quality quantitative data where the key informants were mainly women.

The key data and main indicators we focused on were:

- Agriculture in Area C
- Education
- Work
- Movement
- Violence
- Displacement

Palestinian communities living within the boundary of "Area C" of the West Bank are a population that merits particular development and humanitarian attention due their heightened vulnerability.

Some important facts:

- Most agricultural land in the West Bank is in area C.⁴
- The livelihood of Palestinian households in Area C depends on agriculture.
- Women in Area C are the biggest contributor to the agriculture sector⁵ as unpaid family labour. They make up a higher number than men employed in the same sector.
- Area C is the most sparsely populated area, currently under full Israeli civil administrative and military control.
- Although Area C accounts for over 60% of the area of the West Bank, only 11% of the West Bank Palestinian population dwells there.
- The Palestinian population of Area C is 117,000 living in 19,500 households⁶
- The Israeli settler population in Area C is 325,500 living in 125 settlements and approximately 100 outposts.⁷
- The land designated for Palestinian use is just 1% of area C.⁸

The Process

We began the process by identifying individuals who are subject matter experts on gender or who could contribute to the research and storytelling process (more details in *Profile of Participants below*). We also included information designer, Yosra Gamal, early in the process in order to ensure their immersion in the topic.

³ The 2014 “Area C” Gender/Household Survey ANALYTIC REPORT, Institute of Women’s Studies, Birzeit University / Behalf of Oxfam Novib (2014)

⁴ Applied Research Institute - Jerusalem (2007)

⁵ [PCBS 2016](#)

⁶ Palestinian Central Bureau of Statistics (2012)

⁷ [Btselem](#)

⁸ [OCHA](#) p3

We then identified several data sets that seemed to be interesting or carried the potential for rich data and robust material. We began by familiarizing ourselves with the context, the data from several studies and articles on the topic of women in Area C and building a research brief. Our first trials ended up with four draft design briefs, which we eventually put aside in favour of a brief we developed during the workshop, when the pod participants were all together debating the data, messaging and story-telling angles. The final brief formed the basis of the visualization prototype produced.

The complex and often intersecting data was a challenge to visualize because the more complicated the data visualization components became, the more difficult it was to decode the core message. This led the pod to conclude that an interactive visual would likely provide a simpler interface through which to explore the various layers of data. The pod would also produce a long format infographic and several “data statements” that would zoom in on specific indicators.

The data was segmented into three main areas based on locales in Area C: Urban, Village and Hamlet/Encampment. The women of these locales experience different challenges and threats specific to their location and habitat. As the pod explored the data, it became evident that while the Israeli Civil Administration is responsible for the inhabitants of Area C, in reality, Area C is both figuratively and literally, “off the grid”, with few or no municipal services, underscored ongoing displacement. **Off the Grid** became the title of the series that was prototyped.

The Prototype

The brief views the data through the experiences of three characters, women that typify the life of women in Area C within their own specific setting. Based on this brief, sketches and wireframes were produced by the information designer and the design coded by a web-developer to showcase how an interactive might work. The pod set up a link to a development site where one can view an early prototype. Below are folders that contain the key outputs.

Key Process Learnings

Understanding Data Gaps and Challenges: As the team began delving into the data, several key data related issues arose. For example: Data on the gendered impact of the Israeli occupation is sparse. The pod studied the Palestinian Central Bureau of Statistics figures as a contextual backdrop for the entire oPT and in particular statistical report [Women and Men in Palestine: Issues and Statistics 2016](#) . Pod researchers felt this survey was not nuanced enough, nor did it look at communities that are more severely impacted and where gender inequality is wider than the national average. It was difficult to locate complementary data to fill in the gaps that existed in the PCBS statistics. Knowing this helped the pod focus on data that highlighted the situation of women in the different habitats of Area C, a region that is particularly marginalized and invisible in national studies. The mentoring period proved particularly useful in making these assessments early in the process.

Research Findings & Action points

- **Make gender mainstream in VI programmes:** VI has identified a need (and a responsibility) to capture gender aspects of a data story. In other words, how can VI make sure that our infographic pick up gender specific dimensions? We will endeavour to look at more gender specific data if and when it is available and reflect this in our visuals.
- **Deepen comparative research within gender:** There is an important potential to pursue follow-up research and data visualization to not only compare the situation of Palestinian women vis-a-vis men, but to compare the situation of *particular groups* of women relative to each other: for instance, national data versus Area C data. This approach would have given the pod the opportunity to visualize the situation of women across Palestine. The proposed comparative **intra-gender** research is:
 - Overall oPT including East Jerusalem
 - Overall oPT by region
- **Explore the potential of hybrid visualizations in community work:** The prototype produced is particularly exciting because has the potential to combine a humanizing qualitative approach with the larger issues that are presented quantitatively. This hybrid approach complements and offers the potential for future collaboration with Palestinian HROs and women's organizations such as al Haq or WCLAC, who often document individual case studies.
- **Support civil society groups to collect gendered data:** There are many humanitarian organizations active in Area C, however they have limited gender focus. Donor organizations can support these humanitarian groups to expand their scope of their work to advance the collection of more gender-focused information that may support policy and economic interventions. This data can therefore extend to inform development policies.

Next Steps

Share key learnings: While the Birzeit University/Oxfam report was perhaps a first of its kind in Area C that interviewed female-only respondents to collect both personal and household information, the methodology could have gone further to collect more nuanced gendered data on other indicators, such as education or property ownership. This could have helped better analyse gender gaps within communities in the context of Area C across more indicators. The pod learned that Birzeit University are planning to update the current study (conducted in 2014) and VI would like to follow up with lead researchers to offer them a recommendation on how to strengthen the questionnaire.

Community consultation & partnered release: In the spirit of community consultation, It is important to share the work the pod has realized with the research team at Birzeit university. VI is keen to request Birzeit to critique/challenge the outputs and help build on developing the prototypes further. In the near future, VI plans to finalize, translate into Arabic and release the infographics as part of a partnered release strategy.

Prototype development: As aforementioned, it is important to include the key researchers who worked on the original Area C study in visual development. VI will be organizing this in the coming weeks. Concurrently, VI is in the process of developing a minimum viable product, the poster and online infographic prototypes through its regular design cycles in order to share them with Birzeit as a first step to begin finalization.

The interactive component can be developed further if we secure the necessary funding and can allocate the necessary resources.



From left to right: Yosra Gamal, Nisreen Alami, Bassam Barham, Iman Annab, Sally Shalabi

Profile of Participants

[Nisreen Alami](#) / Independent researcher and gender expert (Amman)

[Sally Shalabi](#) / Facilitator, professional storyteller and local activist, Shalabiyeh (Amman)

[Yosra Gamal](#) / Information Designer, Visualizing Impact (Cairo)

[Bassam Barham](#) / Web developer, Visualizing Impact (Amman)

[Iman Annab](#) / Researcher, Visualizing Impact (Toronto)

Nisreen Alami - Independent researcher and gender expert

Nisreen Alami is a Gender Expert with over twenty years of experience working to ensure response to women's rights in development and humanitarian systems. From 2013 - 2016, Nisreen worked as Senior Humanitarian Gender Advisor to the Humanitarian Country Team in Palestine. Previously, she was Global Policy Advisor for Governance and Financing for Gender Equality at UN Women, New York. She led UNIFEM's global work on Gender Responsive Budgeting between 2001 and 2010 which aimed at aligning policies of national governments on budgeting and development cooperation with gender equality goals. Prior to that, she was responsible for coordinating UNIFEM's programmes in the Arab Region. Nisreen is an Associate of Gender at Work, an international collaborative of gender practitioners supporting

organizations to build cultures of equality and social justice. She has authored and contributed to several publications on women's rights. She holds a Masters degree in Economics and Development Studies from London School of Economics and a BA in Political Science and Economics from the University of Jordan.



"Being part of the gender pod provided me with several tools to overcome the frustrations I had often experienced working previously as a UN Gender Advisor to the humanitarian team in Palestine. When data is inadequate, gender blind and "generic", the stories of women, their experiences, their vulnerability, their exclusion and their rights get sidelined. The mix of the team members working on the VI gender pod helped come up with creative ways to extract data in a way that can build a story that has a human face, that is evidence based and can be communicated effectively. What we managed to produce during the working has the potential to be used to tell stories of different groups of Palestinian women and capture various aspects of their lives and experiences". ~ Nisreen Alami

Sally Shalabi - Facilitator, professional storyteller and local activist

Sally Shalabi today splits her time between storytelling (Shalabieh Al Hakawatieh) and consulting as a facilitator and trainer. She brings twenty years of experience into her work and enjoys being able to merge these two worlds and take different skills into each of them. Her work focuses on community engagement, gender and body politics, and cultural engagement. Sally enjoys a good cup of coffee, knitting, and talking to strangers.



The experience was rich and powerful. Meeting a wonderful group of committed people with a variety of experiences and skills that were cohesive and complimentary was very enriching. I personally learned a lot about the different topics at hand and about translating a big body of data into a digestible and informative piece. I was happy to lend my practice of storytelling to Visualizing Impact and develop a different kind of story that I usually do. ~ Sally Shalabi

Yosra Gamal - Information Designer

Yosra holds a Bachelor degree in Applied Sciences and Arts from the German University in Cairo, Egypt. Her work revolves around sociopolitical and anthropology-related topics that examine the diverse concerns of the region. With a particular focus on constructive research, Yosra aims to deliver her concepts in a variety of mediums that range from infographics, illustrations, photography, and street art, to typography and digital art. Yosra's BA project was exhibited at Global Grad Show 2016 in Dubai. Her work was also featured in the CairoNow exhibition in Dubai, and the 100BAP exhibition in Amman, Abu Dhabi, and Cairo.

Bassam Barham - *Web developer*

Bassam grew up in Bethlehem, Palestine. He then moved to Jordan to get his bachelor's degree in computer engineering. Post graduation, he joined 'Media Plus' for 6 years. From there, Bassam set out on his own as a freelance web developer.

Iman Annab - *Researcher*

Iman is career researcher with over 20 years' experience, specialized in qualitative research, project management, strategy and communication. As an experienced project manager, she excels in design and management of large multi-country studies. Her interest in putting her research skills towards public benefit work, social justice, policy and in particular education, led her to pursue a postgraduate degree at the Ontario Institute for Studies in Education, University of Toronto and was awarded an M.Ed in Social Justice Education. In 2013, she also undertook a certificate in Community Engagement, Leadership and Development to gain the necessary community practice skills to enable her to work with communities. She is an impassioned story-teller and a talented people whisperer and excels in relationship and network building.